

Takeaways

- **Tamil superstar Kamal Haasan is entering the Rajya Sabha via the DMK**
- **With a crossover appeal that works nationally, he can be a voice for Tamil Nadu and the South**
- **His blunderous remark on the birth of Kannada has set off a controversy**
- ***Thug Life*, facing threats now, shows he hasn't left films**

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▶ TAMIL NADU

A NEW ROLE FOR HAASAN

A noisy entry was not on his plan, but the actor has the savvy to be a voice for the South—and DMK—in Delhi

the final crossing. Kamal never made such noises; he gave little away. But it was he who made the decisive move.

In 2018, months after the deaths of J. Jayalalithaa and M. Karunanidhi, he launched Makkal Needhi Maiyam (MNM). As it made an unremarkable debut in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, and stayed a hitless wonder even in the 2021 assembly poll, Kamal likely rationed his expectations. Wisely, he adjusted. Ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha election, he allied with the DMK—a party he considered himself ideologically closer to, and one that recognised his appeal and ability to campaign as a star campaigner. The understanding was clear: Kamal would campaign for the DMK-led alliance and, in return, the party would send him to the Rajya Sabha.

It was a pragmatic choice for both sides. With his voice, articulacy, stature and ideological leanings, Kamal could be a valuable national presence for the DMK. Indeed, in today's mediatised politics, he's a kind of twin asset. He has a profile that works pan-India because of his past Bollywood dalliances, with a crossover appeal none of its other voices in New Delhi have. At the same time, any success at that level will bleed backwards to the DMK's own realms, where he lends a star counterweight to the emerging threat from actor-turned-neta Vijay.

With this nomination, the actor steps into perhaps his most demanding role yet—how demanding is something he has realised early, burning his fingers with the Tamil-Kannada imbroglio. It's not a complete transition either. With *Thug Life*, a reunion with director Mani Ratnam decades after the iconic *Nayagan*, Kamal has signalled that he hasn't left cinema. He seems, for now, committed to straddling both worlds. It was, in fact, at the audio launch for *Thug Life* that he intoned those words, affectionately directing them at actor-producer Shiva Rajkumar, son of Kannada icon Rajkumar. It was meant to connote family bonding, but turned out horribly wrong.

"What I said was out of love," he pronounced later, mixing remorse with a touch of defiance, and tiptoeing around an apology. "I didn't mean anything. Politicians are not qualified to talk about language. They don't have the education to talk about it. That includes me."

Tamil literary great Perumal Murugan, speaking to INDIA TODAY, offered a coda: "What he said is not new. Tamil nationalists say it all the time. They don't stop with claiming paternity to Dravidian languages. They claim all the world's languages were born from Tamil. This is driven by desire more than reason, and is rooted in linguistic chauvinism." That said, he adds, "the correct way to counter an idea is with another idea". Maybe Kamal will get one. ■